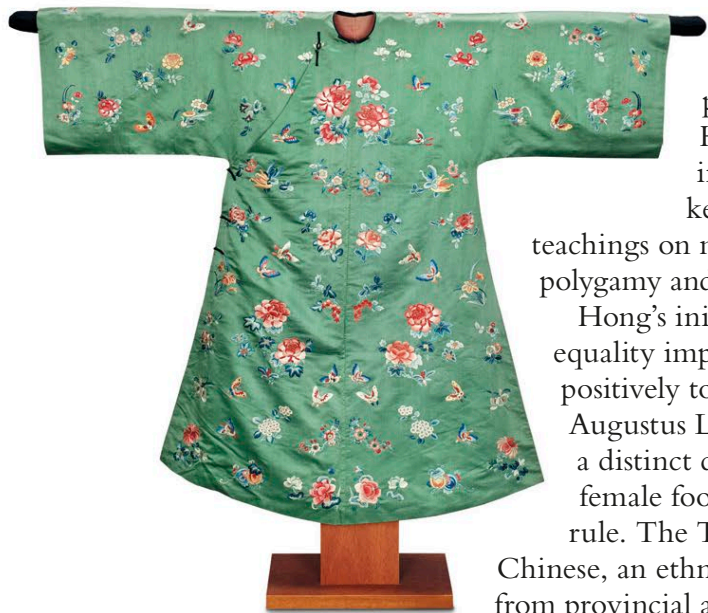


THE FIGHT AGAINST imperialism

THE TAIPING REBELLION

▼ Material privileges

The luxurious silk and satin house robe shown here suggests that the women of the Manchu elite had lives of material privilege, although the Qing system curtailed their social and civil rights.



China's first peasant revolution, the Taiping rebellion of 1850 to 1864, exacted an enormous death toll: between 20 and 30 million people. Beginning in Guangxi Province, the rebellion was a morphing of theology and political activism that criticized the cultural dynamics of the ruling Manchuk-led Qing Dynasty (see pp. 124–125) and the doctrines of Confucianism. By challenging tradition and imperialism, it was also the first movement to address women's rights in China. The Taipings were inspired by the Christian beliefs of European missionaries. Fighting with religious conviction, the rebels based ideas of equality on divine theology: as men and women were both children of God, they were entitled to the same treatment. Led by Hong Xiuquan, the Taipings successfully ruled a significant part of southern China during the middle of the 19th century.

Oppressions lifted

In the aftermath of the rebellion, women's lives under the Taipings improved in several ways. For example, attitudes toward concubinage and prostitution changed. Hong emphasized the importance of virtue in keeping with Biblical teachings on marriage; this led to polygamy and prostitution being banned. Hong's initial intentions regarding equality impacted on Chinese society positively too. British missionary Augustus Lindley noted that there was a distinct decline in the practice of female foot binding under Taiping rule. The Taipings were Hakka Chinese, an ethnic group who originate from provincial areas including Guangxi,

and their societal norms differed from Qing convention. Hakka women did not bind their feet, and the rebels discouraged what they considered to be as an oppressive practice. When the rebellion ended, Christian missionaries and Chinese Protestants continued to lobby against foot binding, leading to the practice being outlawed in the 20th century (see pp. 196–197).

The Taipings also provided women with new employment opportunities. In stark contrast to the domestic roles assigned in the

